

The role of nuts in the optimal diet: time for a critical appraisal?

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During the last decades, nuts have attracted the attention of researchers for their potential benefits in cardiovascular prevention. We discuss here some aspects of the assumed beneficial effects of nuts, weighing them against potential harm. Epidemiological observations and controlled intervention trials consistently suggest that nuts consumption is associated with improved serum lipid profile, thus helping decrease cardiovascular risk. Being nuts an energy dense food, their impact on energy balance and body weight should be considered. In particular, the claim that adding nuts to the habitual diet, thus increasing calorie intake, does not cause body fat accumulation still needs evidence and biological plausibility. The potential risk associated with the relatively frequent occurrence of allergic reactions following the consumption of nuts is also discussed. Copyright © 2012 Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.